RECONSTRUCTION · MISSISSIPPI, 1869–1873

SETTLING UP: FIELD NOTES

Name _____

Family name in the game _____

Date / period _____

You are Robert, a free farmer four years after the Civil War. As you play, stop at each numbered moment and fill in this sheet. Use the blue **In plain words** boxes, the **Almanac**, **Hannah's tally**, and the **Journal** in the game to help you.

The question to keep in mind: Can you be free if you can't leave?

1 WORDS TO KNOW

Fill in as you meet each word. Tap the underlined words in the game for help.

WORD	CLUE	IN MY OWN WORDS
Sharecropper	How is Robert paid for a year of work?	
Lien	Who owns the crop until the debt is paid?	
Furnish	What does the store hand out each spring?	
Credit	When do you pay, and at what price?	
Settling up	What happens every Christmas?	
Carried debt	What happens to money still owed?	

2 THE CONTRACT

January 1869, at the big house

What does Mr. Holliday give the family?

What share of the cotton does the family keep?

Copy the clause that says the family can't sell its own crop. Why does it matter?

3 THE FIVE CROP YEARS

Fill in one row at each Christmas settling up

Year	Store basket Lean / Basic / Extra	Acres of corn 0–5	Event card	His scale weigh-in	Hannah's string true weight	Price per bale	His book says balance	Hannah's tally
1869				lb	lb	$	$	$
1870				lb	lb	$	$	$
1871				lb	lb	$	$	$
1872				lb	lb	$	$	$
1873				lb	lb	$	$	$

Write money you owe with a minus sign (−$29.33). The scale numbers are on the big dial at the gin. Hannah's tally is in the top bar of the game.

In how many years did his book and Hannah's tally disagree? Which one was always lower?

What happened to the price of cotton from 1869 to 1873? (Check the Almanac.)

Contract excerpt adapted from the 1882 Grimes Family Papers (SHEG)

4 KEY MOMENTS Answer when each one happens

The store.
Prices are shown only "on account." Why is buying everything on credit risky for the family?

The field.
Why does the planter want cotton? What does corn do for the family? Why does the contract limit corn to 5 acres?

The scale.
How many pounds apart were his scale and Hannah's string in 1869? Who reads the scale, and can Robert check it?

An event card.
Name one card that hurt the family. Was it the family's fault? Who carried the loss?

Trying to leave. At a settling up, try the button to leave the planter's place. What happens, and what reason does Robert give?

Demanding the books. Did you demand to see the books? ○ Yes ○ No If yes, what hidden line did you see? If no, why not?

5 THE AUDIT After 1873: compare his book with the honest book

CREDIT MARKUP	MISSING COTTON	WITH HONEST BOOKS...
What the higher store prices cost you, all years	Pounds his scale didn't count, all years	could your family have rented a farm? ○ Yes ○ No

Which hidden rule cost your family the most? Use a number.

Name one choice you made that helped or hurt. Did any choice let you get ahead for good?

> *"A man that didn't know how to count would always lose. He might lose anyhow. They didn't give no itemized statement. No, you just had to take their word."*
>
> Henry Blake, formerly enslaved, interviewed for the Federal Writers' Project, Arkansas, 1930s

How does Henry Blake's account match what happened to your family?

6 CAN YOU BE FREE IF YOU CAN'T LEAVE? One TEA paragraph

Topic: your answer in one sentence

Evidence: one number from your game or audit

Analysis: how the system, not bad luck, kept the family in place

Dollar amounts in the game are simplified; the system they show is real.